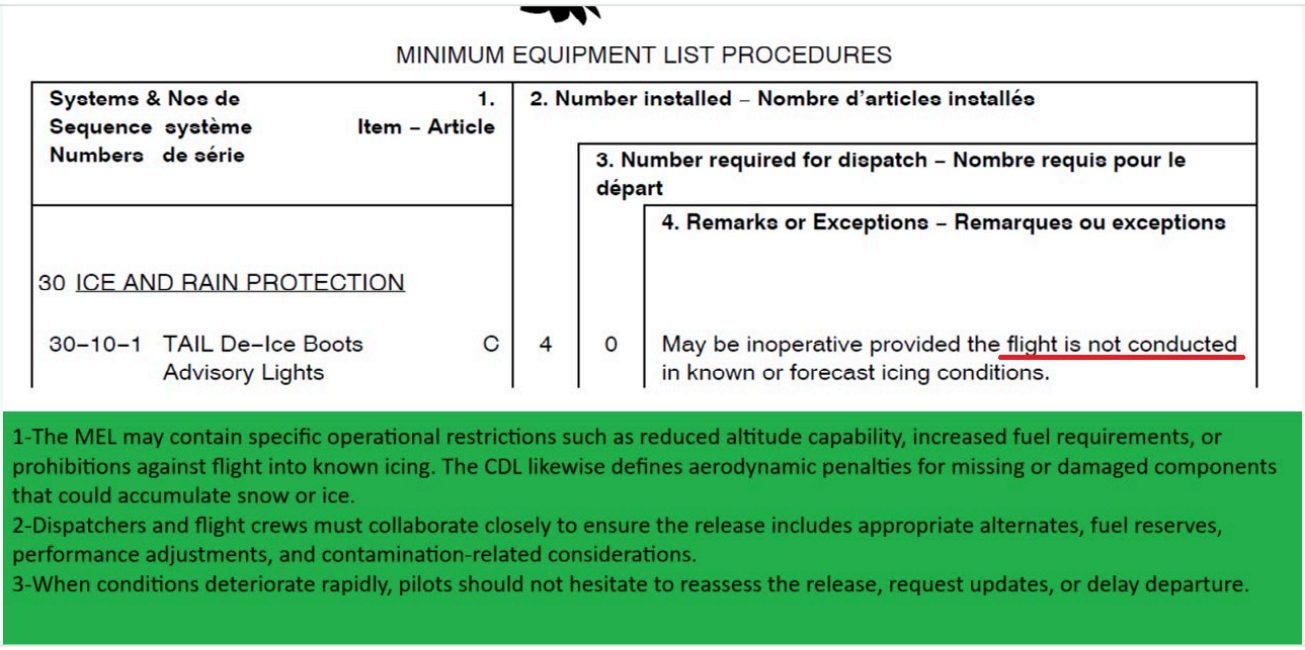
MODULE 6 · OPERATIONS AND HUMAN FACTORS

Lesson 25: Dispatch, MEL/CDL and Winter Flight Planning

Lesson 25 of 30 · about 8 min

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Recognise MEL and CDL items that restrict winter or icing operations.
- Plan alternates and fuel for winter conditions.
- Use NOTAM and SNOWTAM information in flight planning.



MINIMUM EQUIPMENT LIST PROCEDURES

Systems & Nos de Sequence Numbers	1. Item – Article		2. Number installed – Nombre d'articles installés	3. Number required for dispatch – Nombre requis pour le départ	4. Remarks or Exceptions – Remarques ou exceptions
30 ICE AND RAIN PROTECTION					
30–10–1	TAIL De–Ice Boots Advisory Lights	C	4	0	May be inoperative provided the flight is not conducted in known or forecast icing conditions.

1-The MEL may contain specific operational restrictions such as reduced altitude capability, increased fuel requirements, or prohibitions against flight into known icing. The CDL likewise defines aerodynamic penalties for missing or damaged components that could accumulate snow or ice.
2-Dispatchers and flight crews must collaborate closely to ensure the release includes appropriate alternates, fuel reserves, performance adjustments, and contamination-related considerations.
3-When conditions deteriorate rapidly, pilots should not hesitate to reassess the release, request updates, or delay departure.

Read every MEL item for icing restrictions before a winter dispatch.

MEL items with winter impact

Many MEL items allow dispatch with a condition such as *"provided the aircraft is not operated in known or forecast icing conditions"*. In winter, those conditions often make the dispatch impossible. Typical items to check:

- Wing or engine anti-ice valves and controllers;
- Probe and window heat;
- Ice detection system;
- Pneumatic boots and propeller de-ice (turboprops);
- APU — needed for heating, engine starts and, at some stations, for de-icing with the engines shut down;
- Thrust reversers and anti-skid, which affect landing and RTO performance on contaminated runways;
- Windshield wipers and rain repellent.

CDL items (missing panels, seals or fairings) can change the performance and may also allow contamination into structures. Read the full MEL/CDL conditions, including operational (O) and

maintenance (M) procedures.

Weather and aerodrome information

- **SNOWTAM** and **RCR**: runway conditions, cleared widths, snowbanks and the time of observation.
- **NOTAM**: runway and taxiway closures for snow clearing, de-icing facility status, and lighting changes.
- **TAF and forecasts**: precipitation type and timing at departure, destination and alternates.

Alternate selection

- Choose alternates that are not affected by the same weather system, where possible.
- Check runway length against the expected runway condition, and check that de-icing and snow clearing are available.
- Consider the opening hours and handling capability of the alternate in winter, and overnight parking if a return is not possible.

Winter fuel

Add fuel for de-icing delays, extended taxi, a second treatment, holding, and a more distant alternate (see Lesson 22). The commander's extra fuel decision should be based on the specific threats briefed, not on habit.

Stations without de-icing

If an aircraft must overnight at a station without de-icing equipment, consider a hangar, covers, departure time and an alternative plan. The Dryden accident (Lesson 30) shows the danger of a station without the means to de-ice the aircraft properly.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Check every MEL item for icing restrictions — winter conditions often prevent dispatch.
- Use SNOWTAM, RCR, NOTAM and TAF for departure, destination and alternates.
- Choose alternates outside the same weather system, with de-icing available.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

An MEL item allows dispatch "provided the aircraft is not operated in known or forecast icing conditions". The TAF forecasts −SN at departure. Can you dispatch?

A. Yes, provided you avoid clouds

B. No — forecast icing conditions exist at departure

C. Yes, if the item is placarded

D. Yes, at night only

Answer: B. Snow with a temperature of 10 °C or below is a forecast icing condition, so the MEL condition cannot be met.

Training material only. It does not replace the Aircraft Flight Manual, FCOM, QRH, MEL or the Domestic Airlines Operations Manual, which always take precedence.